But as I rethink this whole argument, I'm troubled. Is it too much Buck Rogers? Does it demand an absurd confidence in future technology? Does it ignore my own admonitions about human fallibility? Surely in the short term it's biased against technologically less-developed nations. Are there no practical alternatives that avoid these pitfalls?

All our self-inflicted environmental problems, all our weapons of mass destruction are products of science and technology. So, you might say, let's just back off from science and technology. Let's admit that these tools are simply too hot to handle. Let's create a simpler society, in which no matter how careless or short-sighted we are, we're incapable of altering the environment on a global or even on a regional scale. Let's throttle back to a minimal, agriculturally intensive technology, with stringent controls on new knowledge. An authoritarian theocracy is a tried-and-true way to enforce the controls.

Such a world culture is unstable, though, in the long run if not the short—because of the speed of technological advance. Human propensities for self-betterment, envy, and competition will always be throbbing subsurface; opportunities for short-term, local advantage will sooner or later be seized. Unless there are severe constraints on thought and action, in a flash we'll be back to where we are today. So controlled a society must grant great powers to the elite that does the controlling, inviting flagrant abuse and eventual rebellion. It's very hard—once we've seen the riches, conveniences, and lifesaving medicines that technology offers—to squelch human inventiveness and acquisitiveness. And while such a devolution of the global civilization, were it possible, might conceivably address the problem of self-inflicted technological catastrophe, it would also leave us defenseless against eventual asteroidal and cometary impacts.

Or you might imagine throttling back much further, back to hunter-gatherer society, where we live off the natural products of the land and abandon even agriculture. Javelin, digging stick, bow, arrow, and fire would then be technology enough. But the Earth could support at the very most a few tens of millions of hunter-